

Central America



THE VARIED WILDLIFE of Central America and the islands of the Caribbean Sea reflects the different habitats in the region—from coastal mangrove swamps to grassland and rainforest inland. The climate is always warm, with storms and hurricanes in the summer and fall.

In prehistoric times, animals passed between North and South America along the Central American land bridge. The sea prevented many animals from reaching the Caribbean islands, and several unusual animals, such as the solenodon, have evolved there, where they have few enemies or competitors.

Blood sucker

The vampire bat preys on large mammals, such as cattle. It uses its razor-sharp front teeth to puncture its victim's skin, then laps up the blood that oozes from the wound. It does not take enough blood to kill its victims, but it can pass on diseases in its saliva.

Vampire bat
(*Desmodus rotundus*)
Length: up to 3.5 in (9 cm)
Wingspan: up to 15.7 in (40 cm)

OCELOT

Kinkajou (*Potos flavus*)

Body length: up to 30 in (76 cm)

Tail: up to 22 in (57 cm)

KINKAJOU

GULF OF HONDURAS

RESPLENDENT QUETZAL

CENTRAL AMERICA

VAMPIRE BAT

Lake Managua

Lake Nicaragua

FER-DE-LANCE SNAKE

TRAP-JAW ANT

GOLDEN SCARAB BEETLE

PANAMANIAN GOLDEN FROG

GULF OF PANAMA

PACIFIC OCEAN

Trap-jaw ant

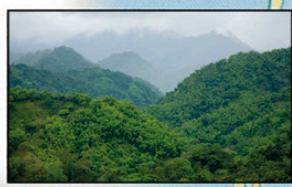
(*Acanthognathus teleeductus*)
Length: up to 0.06 in (1.5 mm)

Trap jaws

The trap-jaw ant has huge jaws, which it uses for hunting or for carrying things. The ant in the picture is carrying a pupa, inside which an adult ant is developing.

Aerial acrobat

The kinkajou spends most of its life in the tops of trees, often hanging by its tail from branches. The kinkajou is also known as the honey bear because it often laps up the honey from bees' nests.



Thick vegetation covers the highland areas on the island of Jamaica.

BEE HUMMINGBIRD

CUBAN SOLENDON

C A R I B B E A N S E A

PANAMANIAN golden frog

(*Atelopus zeteki*)

Length: up to 2.5 in (6.3 cm)

JAMAICA

Golden wonder

This endangered frog is found in the Panama rainforests. It lives by streams and waterfalls. The gushing water is loud, so instead of croaking, they fend off other frogs by waving their feet at them. They lay their eggs on rocks in the fast-flowing current—each tadpole has a sucker on its belly to keep it from being washed away.

Smallest bird

The tiny bee hummingbird is the smallest bird in the world. It beats its wings faster than the human eye can see, at 30–80 beats per second, making a sound like a bee. It feeds on nectar from flowers, but uses up energy quickly because it flies so fast.

Bee hummingbird
(*Mellisuga helenae*)
Length: up to 2.3 in (6 cm)

Deadly snake

The fer-de-lance is one of the most aggressive snakes on Earth—it is quick to strike and injects its prey with a paralyzing venom. The patterns on the snake's skin blend into the leaf litter on the forest floor. This makes the snake almost impossible to spot.

Fer-de-lance snake

(*Bothrops asper*)

Length: up to 8 ft 2 in (2.5 m)